Dr. Koch's Explanation of the Function of His Reagents:

The compound itself is a chain of carbonyl groups with fairly high molecular weight. Our explanation of its action is that it initiates an oxidation chain reaction by chipping of a hydrogen atom from an exposed carbon atom in the toxin molecule, thus producing a radical, which combines oxygen to form a peroxide radical. This peroxide radical acts upon another toxin molecule in the sane way and it forms another peroxide and so the chain is carried by a peroxide of the toxin and this continues until the poison is all oxidized out of the way.